Lab 5 — Workspace Design Exercise

Description

A group design exercise. Working in pairs or small groups, you will propose a workspace layout for the scenario below and justify it. There is no single correct answer — the value is in the trade-offs you can articulate. Paper or whiteboard only; nothing is built.

Learning Objectives

- Apply workspace isolation patterns to a realistic set of requirements.
- Judge when a separation belongs at workspace level and when Unity Catalog handles it better.
- Weigh isolation against the operational overhead of running more workspaces.
- Justify a design decision to a mixed technical and non-technical audience.

Scenario

An organisation is adopting Azure Databricks. It has an actuarial team running models on sensitive policy and claims data, a small data engineering team building ingestion pipelines, and a finance function consuming curated reporting tables. Some source data is subject to strict handling requirements and must not be reachable from non-production environments. Pipelines must be developed and tested before reaching production. Some source systems remain on premises. The platform team is two people.

Your Task

Sketch a workspace layout. For each workspace, state its purpose, its environment, who administers it, and what data it can reach. Then be ready to present your design in five minutes.

Questions to Answer

1. How many workspaces, and what does each one isolate? Business unit, environment, data sensitivity, region — or some combination.
2. Which separations do not need a workspace? Separate workspaces for individual teams or small projects is a recognised anti-pattern; catalogs and schemas in Unity Catalog usually do that job better. Which of your boundaries fall into this category?
3. Classic or serverless? Serverless is the recommended default for operational simplicity. Which requirements in the scenario force classic workspaces instead?
4. Who administers what? A separate workspace means a separate workspace administrator. With a two-person platform team, what does your design cost to run, and does any duty need to be segregated?
5. What would make you revisit it? Name the change in circumstances — a new business unit, a new jurisdiction, a regulatory finding — that would break your design.

Outcome

You can propose a workspace layout for a defined set of requirements, explain which isolation boundaries genuinely need a separate workspace and which are better served by Unity Catalog, and articulate the operational cost that each additional workspace carries.